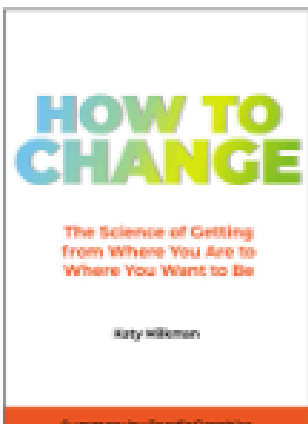




HOW TO CHANGE

The Science of Getting from Where You Are
to Where You Want to Be

KATY MILKMAN



The Big “So What”

Making changes can be hard. In this book, Katy Milkman identifies specific strategies to help you overcome key obstacles to change. By tailoring your strategies to your circumstances, you can successfully build new habits and achieve your goals.



Introduction



In 1994, tennis professional Andre Agassi was feeling frustrated by his under-performance. His new coach Brad Gilbert pointed out that Agassi was trying to make every shot a perfect killer shot, but ended up losing confidence each time he failed to knock out his opponent. Under Gilbert's coaching, Agassi adopted a different approach—to analyze and target his opponents' specific weaknesses. This fueled his resurgence to become the first unseeded tennis player in 28 years to win a U.S. Open trophy.



When it comes to building habits and making changes, many of us make a similar mistake. We try to adopt a one-size-fits-all approach, when it's much more effective to tailor your strategies to your specific challenges and weaknesses.

- In this book, Milkman combines her engineering training with insights from behavioral economics to explain how you can overcome 7 key obstacles to make any change you desire.

THE 7 OBSTACLES TO CHANGE



Not Getting Started



Impulsivity



Procrastination



Forgetfulness



Laziness



Lack of Confidence



Conformity

KEY QUOTES

“One-size-fits-all strategies won't get you nearly as far as tailored attacks on what stands in your way.”

“You can use an all-purpose strategy that works well on average...But you'll get further faster if you customize your strategy: isolate the weakness preventing progress, and then pounce.”

“When it comes to changing your behavior...your opponent is inside your head.”



Overcoming the Obstacles to Change



1. Not Getting Started



Often, we fail to change or achieve our goals because we don't even get started. We may find it hard to break our current routines/habits, or we may lack the belief that we can succeed in the first place.



An ideal time to change is just after a fresh start.

- We tend to think of time in terms of life episodes (e.g. college years, working life, new parent) instead of a continuum. We assign labels to each new chapter (e.g. accounting, consulting, freelancer) which shape how we behave.
- From their research, Milkman and her colleagues uncovered the fresh start effect: people are more likely to do something new or different at the start of new chapters or milestones. For example, in a campaign to help non-savers to save money, they found that people were 20-30% more likely to start saving at a later milestone (e.g. after their next birthday or the start of spring), than to start saving at an arbitrary future date.
- Fresh starts increase our motivation to change because we feel like we're starting from a clean slate. Our past failures seem distant, we feel like a new person and feel more optimistic about the future. So, to begin the change process, start by looking for fresh start opportunities. These could come in the form of:
 - (i) *Calendar dates* that mark new beginnings, e.g. a new year/week, birthdays, anniversaries;
 - (ii) *Meaningful life events*, e.g. surviving a health crisis, moving to a new country; or
 - (iii) *Resets*, e.g. starting again from a blank slate, or resetting your performance scores.



However, there's an important caveat. While fresh starts can trigger positive change, they can also disrupt your progress if you're already on the roll.

KEY QUOTES

"When we hope to change, we have an opportunity to try reshaping our environment to help us disrupt old routines and ways of thinking."

- When Major League Baseball (or MLB) players are traded across leagues mid-season, their statistics for the season are reset. However, the statistics are not reset for trades within leagues. One of Milkman's PhD students analyzed 40 years of MLB data, and found that below-average players tended to improve after a statistical reset, whereas above-average players tended to do worse after a reset (since they must rebuild their records from scratch).
- Similar outcomes were found in other performance studies: resets can help underperformers to up their game, but they can also hurt people who're already performing well.



2. Impulsivity



Impulsivity refers to the present bias, or our natural preference for activities that are instantly gratifying (e.g. having an ice-cream) over those that yield long-term benefits (e.g. going to the gym).

- Don't rely on willpower alone to overcome your resistance to painful or difficult activities, as you'll be fighting an uphill battle.
- Instead, make your natural instincts work for you by redesigning tasks to make them instantly gratifying. For example:
 - (i) Psychologists Ayelet Fishbach and Kaitlin Woolley ran experiments where participants were encouraged to exercise and eat more healthy food. Those who were told to choose the most *enjoyable* activities/food did much better than those who were asked to choose the most *beneficial* activities/food.
 - (ii) At Stockholm's Odenplan metro station, 66% of visitors voluntarily took the stairs (instead of elevators) after the staircase was transformed into a set of working piano keys, making it fun to walk up/down the steps.



Temptation bundling is about linking a pleasurable-but-undesirable activity with a virtuous-but-unpleasant activity.

KEY QUOTES

- This serves 2 simultaneous objectives: reduce the time spent on temptations, and increase the time spent on valuable activities that serve your long-term goals. For example, if you dread going to the gym but love watching Netflix, then only allow yourself to watch Netflix while you're working out at the gym.
 - (i) In a study, participants were given ipods with interesting audiobooks for a gym session. They were told about the benefits of temptation bundling, and instructed to return to the gym if they wanted to finish the audiobooks.
 - (ii) Of these participants, some were given a free audiobook download—7% of this group still revisited the gym. For the remaining participants, the ipods were locked in the gym lockers, and 55% of this group actually revisited the gym!
- This shows that the knowledge of temptation bundling is already useful in itself, though it's much more effective if you can actually restrict the indulgence to prevent cheating.



You can also make an activity instantly gratifying through gamification.

- The idea is to add game-like features (e.g. contests, leaderboards, symbolic rewards) to make an activity fun and engaging.
 - (i) This is already being used by many companies. For example, Wikipedia uses a recognition system to motivate its volunteer editors, Cisco gamified a program to help employees develop social media skills, while SAP gamified awards and badges to boost employees' sales performance.
 - (ii) Gamification has even been used in clinical rehabilitation programs, e.g. using video games that simulate kayak paddling to help stroke patients recover faster.
- However, gamification only works if participants buy in to the game/goals, making it fun/exciting to do something they already want to do. It can backfire if people feel compelled to participate.

"Gamification can help many of us tackle our goals, so long as we're choosing to use it to pursue goals we want to achieve."



3. Procrastination



Our present bias doesn't only cause us to prioritize instant gratification. It also leads us to procrastinate on less enjoyable tasks, including those that serve our long-term goals.



Economic principles say that, all else being equal, people will always choose to have more freedom. Yet, numerous studies have shown that (i) people may willingly restrict themselves to overcome unwanted temptations, and (ii) those who do so tend to achieve much better results than those who don't.

- In the early 2000s, about 31% of families in the Philippines were below the poverty line. The Green Bank sought to get people to save more—a goal that would benefit both the bank and their customers. They decided to try a new product: a "locked" bank account that offered customers the same interest rates as normal savings accounts, but prevented them from taking out the money until they reached a pre-selected date or account balance.
 - (i) Surprisingly, 28% of the customers chose the more restrictive option even though the interest rates were the same as normal accounts.
 - (ii) Those 28% ended up saving 80% more the following year compared to customers who chose a normal savings account.
- Dan Ariely and Klaus Wertenbroch ran an experiment to help MIT students to complete assignments on time. To pass the course, students had to hand in 3 papers by the end of the term. Half the students were given the option to voluntarily set *earlier* deadlines and to be penalized for each day they were late.
 - (i) 68% of the students chose the restrictive option because they wanted to pace their assignments instead of waiting to finish everything only at the end of the term.
 - (ii) The students who chose the self-imposed deadlines ended up submitting assignments with 50% fewer errors.

KEY QUOTES

 Unfortunately, not everyone realizes how susceptible they are to temptations. “Naifs” are people who overestimate their level of self-control or willpower. On the other hand, “sophisticates” understand the limits of self-control and willpower, and use commitment devices to overcome temptation and procrastination. A commitment device is something that restricts your freedom to serve a bigger goal.

- “Hard” commitments involve concrete restrictions or penalties.
 - (i) For example, you can put yourself on a casino’s exclusion list to prevent yourself from gambling, or choose a “locked” savings account to prevent yourself from withdrawing the money until you’ve reached your savings goal.
 - (ii) You can also create your own cash commitment device by putting money on the line. Simply set a goal and get someone to hold you accountable—if you fail to reach the goal, you’ll pay your friend a penalty or contribute the money to charity.
- You can also make a public declaration as a “soft” commitment.
 - (i) Doctors were 30% less likely to prescribe inappropriate antibiotics after they signed and displayed a formal pledge.
 - (ii) You can also apply other soft restrictions, e.g. using a smaller plate to reduce the amount of food intake.
- Generally, hard commitments are more effective but less palatable than soft commitments. Make it easier to stick to your commitments by breaking down a big goal into bite-size commitments. For instance, you’re more likely to save \$3 a day than to save \$1095 a year (even though both amounts are the same).

KEY QUOTES

“Many of us choose not to adopt commitment devices because we undervalue them or are naïve about how much we need them.”

“If a commitment is bite-size, it appears less daunting to us, and we’re more likely to stick to our word.”



4. Forgetfulness

 We may intend to do something but fail to follow through because we simply forget.

- A study found that 54% of registered voters in the USA said they intended to vote, but failed to turn up on Election Day. Health company Evive found that 70% of their clients' employees don't show up for free flu vaccinations.
- One of the most common reasons for flaking out is that people forget. Psychologist Hermann Ebbinghaus estimated that people forget almost 50% of what they learn within 20 minutes; they forget about 70% of what they learn within 24 hours.

 Timely reminders are one of the best cures for forgetfulness.

- Reminders (such as alarms or email prompts) can reduce flaking out by about 8% on average. However, the most effective prompts should happen just before the intended activity.
- In a study, drivers were reminded to buckle their seat belts when they collected their vehicles from the valet. Those who received the reminder *just as they stepped into their cars* buckled their seat belts 80% of the time. On the other hand, there was no difference between drivers who were reminded a few minutes before collecting their vehicles, and those who received no reminders—both groups buckled their seat belts only 55% of the time. This shows that we can forget a reminder within a few minutes.

 Cue-based plans are another great way to overcome forgetfulness. This is about linking a plan of action with a specific cue, i.e. "When ____ happens, I'll do ____."

- A cue is anything that triggers your memory. It can be:
 - (i) A specific date/time, e.g. 5pm on Monday;
 - (ii) A location, e.g. the bus-stop outside your house;
 - (iii) An object, e.g. a cup of coffee;
 - (iv) An activity, e.g. stopping your alarm in the morning; or
 - (v) An event, e.g. getting a pay raise.

KEY QUOTES

"There are many things we routinely forget to do in spite of having good intentions."

KEY QUOTES

- Instead of saying "I'll exercise more" or "I'll save more", it's more effective to build your plan around specific cues. For example, "Every Monday, Wednesday and Friday at 5pm I'll go to the gym" or "When I get my salary, I'll save 5%." 62% of students who used cue-based planning achieved their holiday goals, compared with just 22% of students who using general planning.
- A vivid, distinctive cue (e.g. a stuffed green alien on a cash register or a purple rabbit) is much more effective in triggering recall than a generic cue (e.g. a cash register or normal rabbit).
- Cue-based plans are the most effective in cases where people have not made detailed plans for an event or goal. The very act of planning increases the likelihood of action because it:
 - (i) Creates psychological commitment;
 - (ii) Forces you to break down a vague goal into smaller, specific chunks; and
 - (iii) Removes the need for in-the-moment decisions.

For example, Evive saw a 13% increase in vaccinations just by sending letters to employees to think about and jot down the intended date and time for their free flu shot.

- To combine cue-based plans with timely reminders, get people to think about how, where and when they would take action, then set a timely reminder with vivid cues.



There are a couple of caveats to take note of:

- Cue-based plans only work if people already want to do something; and
- Too many cue-based plans can become overwhelming. So, (i) focus on a few key goals and (ii) use checklists if a plan gets too complex to remember.

"The more vivid, catchy, and thus memorable the cue, the more likely it is to do its job and help us recall our plans."

"Planning forces you to do the critical work of breaking it down."



5. Laziness



It's human tendency to take the path of least resistance. We may stick to a comfortable routine even though it obstructs our goals, e.g. binge-watching TV instead of completing our MBA assignments.



The great news is, you can use laziness to your advantage. Behavioral scientists regularly use set-it-and-forget-it systems to nudge people to behave in a certain way.

- To get doctors to prescribe generic medicines, Penn Medicine added a checkbox that's set to generic prescriptions by default, so the doctors had to intentionally uncheck the box to prescribe branded medications. This simple adjustment increased generic meds prescription from 75% to 98%. People are also more likely to save if it's a default to contribute a portion of their salary into a savings plan unless they opt out.



However, such nudges may not work for behaviors that require a repeated decision (e.g. to exercise daily). In such cases, our existing habits will dictate our default behavior.

- Habits are formed when we're rewarded consistently—e.g. getting praises, emotional relief, or pleasure—by responding to a cue in a specific way. Once formed, our habits act like behavioral shortcuts, i.e. we'll perform the action automatically in response to the cue, even if the reward is removed.
- We can drill desirable behaviors until they become habits that we perform by default, e.g. having a healthy smoothie in the morning instead of oily bacon. In a study, participants were paid to exercise at a gym for a month. Those who were paid to exercise 8x a month continued to exercise more in the subsequent weeks compared to those paid to exercise once a month.
- However, an overly-rigid habit can backfire. To make your habits "stickier", build flexibility into your routine wherever possible.
 - (i) Employees who were rewarded to visit the gym at a specific time were more likely to continue the routine

KEY QUOTES

"Laziness can be an asset...When laziness is properly harnessed, it can actually help facilitate change."

"Too much rigidity is the enemy of a good habit."

compared to those who were rewarded for visiting the gym whenever they liked.

- (ii) However, once the schedule for the first group was disrupted, they stopped going to the gym altogether, while the flexible group continued to visit the gym at their convenience.



Unfortunately, there's no fail-safe for maintaining a habit. To build and sustain a habit, it helps to:

- Track your behavior, e.g. marking your activity on a calendar each time it's completed. This helps you to remember the activity, hold yourself accountable, and celebrate each successful action.
- Aim for streaks, i.e. a period of consistent, unbroken action. Comedian Jerry Seinfeld generates a joke daily, while founding father Benjamin Franklin tracked his success habits for 13 virtues. Avoid consecutive lapses (e.g. missing a few visits to the gym) as it can easily break a habit.
- You can also piggyback on existing habits, i.e. peg a new habit (e.g. journaling) to an existing, stable habit (e.g. drinking your morning coffee).



6. Lack of Confidence



Self-doubt can stop people from setting a goal or taking the necessary steps to attain them.

- When we see someone struggling, we may offer unsolicited advice to help them. Unfortunately, this ends up reducing their confidence to make things worse.
- Instead, it's better to ask the other person for advice.



Boost your confidence by giving solicited advice.

- Psychologist Lauren Eskreis-Winkler found that people were more motivated to achieve their goals when they were asked for advice than when they were offered advice. Milkman and her colleagues found that high school students improved their grades after giving advice to other students.

KEY QUOTES

"The most versatile and robust habits are formed when we train ourselves to make the best decision, no matter the circumstances."

"When we don't believe we have the capacity to change, we don't make as much progress changing."

KEY QUOTES

"If giving advice can destroy confidence, then asking people who are struggling to be advisers....might be a better approach."

- Asking people for advice is so effective because:
 - (i) It conveys our belief in them, signals that they have something worthwhile to share and builds their confidence.
 - (ii) In the process of giving advice, the other party has to consider the strategies for achieving certain goals. Since they'll feel hypocritical if they don't follow their own advice, they also become more motivated to take action.
- To create opportunities for offering solicited advice:
 - (i) Form an advice club where members solicit help/advice from one another;
 - (ii) Volunteer for a mentoring role; or
 - (iii) Ask yourself: if someone were to ask you for help on the problem at hand, what advice would you give?



Manage your expectations to shape your behavior and reality.

- Our expectations affect our outcomes because our beliefs shape our emotions, what we focus on, how motivated we feel, and even our physiology.
 - (i) Housekeepers who were told that their work was a form of exercise started to lose weight (unlike the control group which didn't receive the same message).
 - (ii) People who thought they were consuming a high-fat, high-calorie milkshake felt fuller than those who thought they were consuming a no-fat, low-calorie milkshake. In reality, both groups were given the same beverage.
- Sometimes, a small mistake can lead to a downward spiral because we expect ourselves to keep failing. To prevent that:
 - (i) Create some *allowance* when you set ambitious goals, e.g. aim to exercise daily, but allow up to 5 missed days a month for emergencies. This builds flexibility into your habits and helps you to stay confident in face of inevitable setbacks.

(ii) Adopt a *growth mindset* and rethink your definition of “failure”. Realize that your abilities are not fixed, and every setback is an opportunity to learn and grow.

(iii) Use *self-affirmation* and focus on experiences that make you feel positive about yourself.



7. Conformity

→ We feel pressured to follow what others are doing because we want to fit in or we assume they know something that we don't. We're more likely to conform if (i) we feel uncertain about what to do, and/or (ii) the other person's traits or circumstances closely resemble ours.

→ You can turn this tendency to your advantage by surrounding yourself with people who'll influence you positively.

- Spending time around high-caliber people can expand your capacity and perspectives, whereas being around low achievers can do the opposite.
- Milkman's studies found that people are more likely to achieve their goals if they copy and adapt others' solutions instead of developing plans on their own. If you need ideas and inspiration for your goals, start by emulating the strategies and tactics of those who've already achieved what you want to achieve. You can always adjust their approach for your circumstances.

→ You can also influence others' behaviors by highlighting what's normal or typical, e.g. “63% of hotel guests reuse their towels to save water.”

- However, social influence tactics can backfire if there's too big a gap or difference between achievers and non-achievers. For example, weak students who were grouped with strong students became demoralized because they felt it was impossible to bridge the gap. Employees were less likely to opt in to a savings program when they were told that most of their colleagues were already saving successfully.

KEY QUOTES

“We feel like misfits when we stand out from the crowd.”

“When harnessed to help people, social norms can play a valuable role in changing our behavior for the better.”

- We want to look good in front of others (e.g. our friends, colleagues, neighbors). So, we're more likely to do the "right thing" if we believe we're being watched.
 - (i) In a study to promote green energy, homeowners were asked to sign up on a public bulletin where their neighbors could see who had (or had not) signed up. This yielded 3x more sign-ups compared to communities where the sign-ups were anonymous.
 - (ii) As a rule of thumb, it's better to let people opt in to a chance to earn public praise, than to force them to do something to avoid public shaming.
- If a behavior is not yet widely-adopted, you can still leverage social influence by sharing an upward trend, e.g. "The number of people on the voluntary retirement scheme has doubled since last year".
- Social influence tactics work best when you focus on tangible, instantly-achievable goals. So, break down a big goal into small, achievable goals, and use social norms to encourage people to sustain their efforts.



Conclusion and Other Details in the Book

The tools in this book can help you to overcome obstacles to change and to form helpful habits. However, the only way to achieve permanent, transformative change is to continually apply the techniques. Evaluate your obstacles as your goals and circumstances change, and adjust your game plan accordingly.

In this summary, we've captured the key insights on how to change. The book includes many other examples and references to help you understand and apply the concepts. For more details, please visit www.katymilkman.com.

KEY QUOTES

"Creating social accountability can dramatically change our behavior."

"Transformative behavior change is more like treating a chronic disease than curing a rash."